LSM3259 – Creative Assignment

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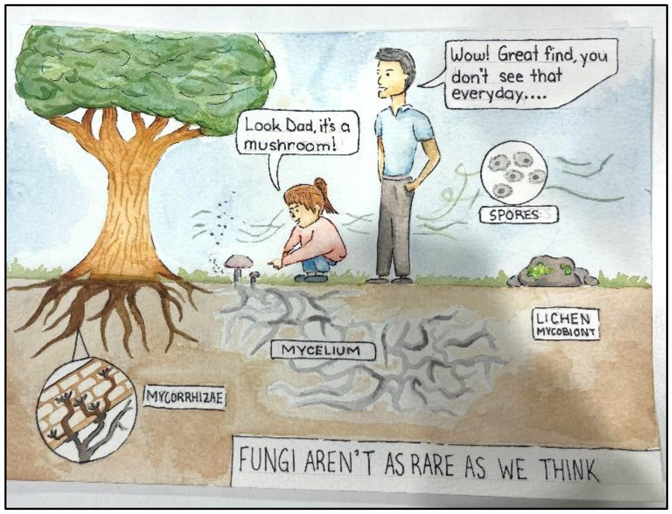

Fungi are ubiquitous in the natural world, and yet a large proportion of the world's population has almost zero knowledge on these organisms. Fungi account for close to 20% of all eukaryotic species, and yet most public citizens cannot recognize, nor identify fungal species (Schanz & Remmele, 2026). This concept, known as fungal blindness, refers to how a large amount of people are unaware of the ecological presence and importance of fungal diversity (Waller, 2025). Public awareness of fungi is often limited to only the observable macro structures or fruiting bodies, which represent a very limited proportion of fungal organisms. Fruiting bodies are rarely produced by only a few select phyla of fungi, and majority of fungal organisms exist in other forms such as mycelium (Hardy, 2026).

Fungi perform a vast array of ecological services and therefore act as an integral ecosystem component that must be accounted for in conservation efforts. Yet widespread fungal blindness, in both public and scientific populations, is a barrier to fungal conservation (Torres-

Porras et al., 2025). The knowledge gap on fungi functions creates a lack of understanding on the necessity to maintain fungal diversity for the sake of preserving ecosystem integrity (Waller, 2025). This knowledge gap is partially driven by the fact that majority of ecosystem processes are performed by fungi that are not visible to the naked eye, such as mycorrhizae and mycelium networks (Hardy, 2025). Minimal visual awareness and sensory perception of fungi is one of factors that contributes to fungal blindness (Waller, 2025).

The presented art piece was created with the aim of drawing attention to ecologically important but commonly overlooked fungal organisms and structures. The captured conversation was meant display two concepts, 1) majority of people think fungi exist only as mushrooms and 2) people are often oblivious to the fact that they are constantly surrounded by fungi in a variety of forms. It was hoped that visually depicting the concept of fungal blindness would help draw the viewer's attention to their own unawareness on fungi diversity. Moreover, the medium choice, comprehendible terminology, and simplified concept was specifically chosen so that the artwork could be understood by an expansive audience range. Within conservation, the largest action inhibitor commonly boils down to a lack of public support, public misinformation, or communication barriers between the science community and public sphere. Ergo, to address fungal blindness and promote conservation the most useful tools are those which can be widely appreciated. It was hoped that the artwork would inspire viewer's to acknowledge their existing fungi blindness and further encourage curiosity about the role of fungi in the environment.

References

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